

I wanted to be a doctor. I remember his response very clearly: “I don’t think that’s a very good fit.” My dad will always give you the truth, beginning his sentence with an awkward chuckle to hide his discomfort when his candor requires imparting an opinion he knows you don’t want to hear. I didn’t take his advice immediately, but it wasn’t long into my first year of college when I realized he had been right. I am more of a creative type, and being a doctor was probably not a good fit. I switched to film school in New York.

To help spark my interest in investing, my father had given me a \$500 Ameritrade account. I found a few recommendations online and bought three stocks. Two of my stocks continued to climb higher; the third, CSX, hovered in a range somewhere between \$30 and \$40. I called my dad. I was ready to impress him with my insight. Having noted the stock’s trading pattern, I told him that I planned to sell it near \$40 and then buy it back near \$30. He was not impressed. He chuckled and said, “Yeah, people do that.” Two years later my account was up over two thousand dollars. I recognized I knew remarkably little about the stock market and assumed that I had probably just been lucky. I liquidated my portfolio and bought a film camera.

My father was coming to New York to give a talk at a trading expo. He extended an invitation to me, which I cautiously accepted. I pulled out my only collared shirt from the bottom of the closet and made my way to the Hilton Times Square. Everybody was wearing suits, and I instantly felt uncomfortable. My mother, whom my dad refers to as his best long-term trade, was already seated. I walked over and sat next to her. She greeted me with one of her favorite comments: “You’re such a handsome boy, but nobody would ever know by the way you are dressed.” The room filled up, and my dad walked up to the podium. Everyone seemed extremely excited to hear what he had to say. I sank into my seat and hoped I would understand enough so that I could say something nice to him when it was over. I didn’t know this moment would change the course of my life.

My dad began to speak. I waited for his words to drift beyond my realm of comprehension, but that moment never came. Einstein once said, “Any intelligent fool can make things bigger, more complex, and more violent. It takes a touch of genius—and a lot of courage—to move in the opposite direction.” My father has always had the ability and desire to take complex